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Case
FIFA 2010:
Choosing the Best Coach in the World

Originally, awards for the best football coaches were presented by World Soccer magazine, which has conferred a yearly prize called the 'The Best Coach of the Year' since 1982; one with the same name was also awarded annually by the International Federation of Football History & Statistics (IFFHS) since 1996. However, neither of these awards received as much media attention as the *Fédération Internationale de Football Association* (FIFA). In 2010, the magazine *France Football* (an Amaury media group company) and FIFA joined together to present one single award for the 'World Player of the Year' in both male and female categories and the 'World Coach of the Year'.

The first awards ceremony took place on January 10, 2011 in Zurich (Switzerland). Voting opened in the last week of October 2010 and closed a month later. On December 6 of the same year, FIFA chose the three finalists: Vicente del Bosque, Pep Guardiola, and José Mourinho. Since this was the first time that awards would be given to coaches, the panel was responsible for making a choice that would convince global football fans while not jeopardizing FIFA's credibility given there was already a cloud of doubt hanging over the institution for other non-sport related issues. The finalists' three personalities clashed: all of them successful yet with very different visions of football and leadership. This led the panel to an intense debate on the following issues: What was the most important criteria to select the best World Coach of the Year? Which of the three candidates was the most complete leader? Who should be awarded the first prize for 'The Best World Coach of the Year'?

AUTHORSHIP CREDITS

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A HUGE GLOBAL PHENOMENON

Along with many other international organizations, FIFA's head office is in Zurich, Switzerland. In 2010 there were 209 affiliated National Associations, which, at that time, made it the International Organization with the largest amount of Member Nations. In that sense, it even surpassed the United Nations (UN), which only had 193 country members. In the 2010 FIFA World Rankings, Spain was ranked top, and San Marino was ranked last (FIFA, 2016).

According to Horacio González, based on industry data, football has historically been the sport with the largest fandom and followers throughout the world. As the Argentinian sociologist and essayist stated, it is a sport that elicits passions in the five continents:

> Football is usually referred to as "a passion of crowds". This is a good thing, as passions are expressed in large groups. Football shows us the long-standing association between passions and intimacy. This refers to the allocations of private passions to the world of sports, a world with the particularity of requiring a large number of spectators. As such, the condition of the spectator reproduces classic tragic theatre. As with all distortions, the football spectator is heir to the tragic spectator (Martínez, 2003).

Eduardo Galeano shares a similar opinion. He believes that football has an even greater, more serious, and transcendental connotation: it is a complex rational and emotional event in which firm beliefs are expressed, both rational and irrational, that are realized through forms of behavior, ceremonies, or rituals that require often-prominent chants, prayers, and sacrifices.

> For this reason, the Uruguayan teacher and scholar is convinced that, Football is the mirror of the world and the only religion without atheists (Galeano, 2017, p. 185).

Research undertaken by Deloitte (2011) revealed that in 2010 football was the world's 17th economy: larger than nations such as Switzerland, Belgium, and Taiwan. If it was a country, football would have a Gross Domestic Product (GDP) of USD $500,000 million. This research states that over 270 million people, more than 4% of the world´s population have some type of connection to this sport. It also states that football was played by 240 million players, belonging to 1.5 million teams.

One of the events that best exemplifies football being "the sport of masses" is the World Cup, which is organized by FIFA every four years. The first competition took place in 1930 in Uruguay, and the hosts beat Argentina in the final to win the Cup. World Cups have turned into very lucrative businesses thanks to media, sponsors, and merchandizing. As a global event, the World Cup attracts the attention of the world's most important brands.

The business of World Cups is more profitable for FIFA than for the countries that host them since they function as a type of franchise owned by FIFA. Countries from the five continents compete to become World Cup hosts as there are always many economic, media, and, often, political interests. Selecting the host country has historically been a controversial process. One of the most

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serious accusations is that FIFA executives are given attractive sums of money or luxury items to swing the balance in favor of a certain country.

According to official figures, FIFA earned USD $2,400 million in the 2010 South Africa World Cup through sponsorships alone. It also sold USD $220 million in tickets for the best seats in stadiums and earned USD $180 million in licenses, which was 30% more than the World Cup in Germany in 2006. One fact that reinforces the impact and size of this industry is that the best fiscal year in the history of football was 2008: in the midst of a global economic crisis. That year, FIFA earned EUR 674 million in income and a net profit of EUR 129 million, which was 375% more than in 2007 (FIFA, 2016).

Another clear example that football is a global phenomenon of the masses is the impact of the Awards that FIFA grants to the best players (both male and female) every year since 1991. Since 2010, the award was only presented to the best female player as FIFA and Amaury media group, owner of the sports newspaper France *Football*, made an agreement whereby the FIFA *World Men's Player of the Year and the Ballon d'Or* would become one prize called the FIFA *Ballon d'Or*. In 2011, it was decided that the previous year's best coaches would also be granted an award.

SOME OF THE WORLD'S GREAT CHAMPIONSHIPS

In the 2010 season, one of the main factors to be chosen as the World Coach of the Year, were the achievements obtained during November 2009 to November 2010. Each championship had its own particular characteristics. The following is a summary of these championships based on information available from the Federations' webpages and several press releases:

1. World Cup. FIFA World Cup is the most important, official international men's football tournament. A total of 32 National Teams compete every four years. As teams from five continents participate, it is the most prestigious football tournament in the world. To win the World Cup, each team has to go through a qualifying phase during which the number of matches varies depending on each continent, and then the elimination matches start: there are approximately a total of seven matches.

2. Champions League. The UEFA Champions League (previously known as the European Cup) is an official international tournament for the most successful football clubs that play against other European clubs. The Champions League is considered as the second most prestigious football tournament as Europe has the largest number of top-class football players as well as the most World Cup wins (10 compared to 9 for the Americas). 32 teams compete to win the Champions League, and they generally play thirteen games.

3. National Leagues. Each country's national top-league championship is a professional tournament for the highest-ranked male football clubs. It is the most important

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and difficult tournament in each country: a competition between twenty teams that, generally, play each other twice: once at their home stadium and once away, which gives a total of 38 games.

4. National Cup. This is a national football competition that is a knockout tournament played between first, second, and third division sides: between professional and non-professional teams. There are differences between the competitions in each country. The prestige of the cup mainly lies in the fact that a large number of teams take part (92 in England, 84 in Spain, and 78 in Italy), that it has a direct elimination format, and that the winner of the tournament plays in the Super Cup. This is a national tournament where the winner of the national league plays the winner of the national cup.

Coaches' achievements in these competitions had their own merits and were possible thanks to a combination of leadership and technical skills as well as their relationship with the players. The role of the coach has become particularly relevant because of their level of professionalism and the different characteristics of championships.

THE IMPORTANCE OF THE COACH

Divulging, establishing techniques and developing tactical and strategic knowledge has set the individuals apart who, with their leadership, establish and execute the decisions and instructions that guide a football team in the field: the coach or technical director.

> We used to have a trainer, but no one paid much attention to them. The trainer died a quiet death when the game stopped being a game and modern football needed technocratic order. The coach, or technical director was born. Their mission was to avoid improvisation, control individual freedoms, and maximize players' performances: forcing them to become disciplined athletes. (Galeano, 2019, p. 12).

This is how the Uruguayan writer explains the rise of the importance of the coach at the heart of the football team, within a context that forces him to speak the language of numbers.

The professionalization of the game led to approaches becoming more technical and the subsequent development of know-how aimed at increasing the chances of winning. Appropriately applying technical knowledge, depending on the characteristics of the opposing team, is one of the coach´s main objectives. Their function is also to reduce unpredictability: meaning, what cannot be foreseen, with a plan carried out by actors with unique personalities, freedoms and passions, backgrounds, changing motivations, and particular conflicts that are not always evident. The combination of all these variables sometimes results in an extremely complex sporting performance that cannot always be predicted or trained for.

The modern coach, thus, needs to optimally manage this set of human and social complexities. They need to be a figure with, not only technical skills but also human, mainly emotional and

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persuasive talents, and pedagogical abilities. High-performance coaches are required to have leadership abilities, such as those of a conductor who needs to achieve the perfect performance by encouraging the best out of every musician. In short, the modern coach is a coordinator of individuals and complexities. Their leadership skills will allow them to turn a group of players into a team, and this, in turn, into a winning system.

Diverse organizations have created different commendations of the best coaches' achievements. For example, the award for the best football coach was presented by *World Soccer* magazine, which has conferred an award with its name to the 'Coach of the Year' since 1982. The International Federation of Football History & Statistics (IFFHS) has also granted a 'Coach of the Year' award since 1996. However, neither of these awards has received as much media attention as the Award to be granted by FIFA in January 2011 and that would acknowledge the achievements, in terms of the number of championships won and managers' leadership qualities, between November 2009 and November 2010.

The official ten-candidate list for the World Coach of the Year was released on October 26, 2010:

- ≈ Carlo Ancelotti (Italy/Chelsea FC).
- ≈ Vicente del Bosque (Spain/Spanish National team).
- ≈ Alex Ferguson (Scotland/Manchester United FC).
- ≈ Pep Guardiola (Spain/FC Barcelona).
- ≈ Joachim Low (Germany/German National team).
- ≈ José Mourinho (Portugal/FC Internazionale Milano and FC Real Madrid).
- ≈ Oscar Tabárez (Uruguay/Uruguayan National team).
- ≈ Louis van Gaal (Holland, FC Bayern Munich).
- ≈ Bert van Marwijk (Holland/Netherlands National team).
- ≈ Arsene Wenger (France/Arsenal FC).

On December 6 of the same year, FIFA chose the shortlist of their best candidates based on their achievements in the most recent football season. The three finalists were Vicente del Bosque, Pep Guardiola, and José Mourinho. As previously explained, the modern football coach needs to be able to coordinate individuals and their corresponding complexities: a coach's leadership skills turn a team of players into a winning system. The awards achieved during the 2010 season by Del Bosque, Guardiola, and Mourinho were won by their own hard and almost equal work, although, from a leadership point of view, each one had his own particular style. The following section presents each coach's profile and includes a short biography, their journey as players, and their beginnings at coaching. The highlights of their season are then detailed, as well as their main personality traits and their relationships with their players.

1.Vicente del Bosque (Spain/Spanish National team). Won the World Cup with the Spanish national team in the South Africa World Cup 2010.

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He was born in Salamanca on September 23, 1950. He played for Castilla, Cordoba FC, CD Castellón, and Real Madrid FC. While playing for Real Madrid FC, he won five "La Liga" trophies and four "Copa del Rey" trophies. He played internationally for Spain 18 times and played in the 1980 European Championships.

When he finished his playing career, Del Bosque started coaching the lower levels of Real Madrid FC. In 1994, he debuted as first team coach by succeeding Benito Floro, but only held the position for several months and then later returned to the team's lower leagues. He was also in charge of the team in 1996 after Jorge Valdano. He coached the first team for just one game and beat Athletic Club de Bilbao 5-0 in San Mamés. Arsenio Iglesias then took over coaching the *Merengues*. Finally, in the 1999/ 2000 season he was appointed first team coach, replacing Welshman John Benjamin Toshack. Under his leadership, the team reached the Champions League Final and beat Valencia by 3-0 in Paris, thus winning the eighth title for the 'Casa Blanca' in the prestigious European cup.

In his four seasons as first team coach, Del Bosque won two Champions Leagues (2000 and 2002), two 'Ligas' (2001 and 2003), a Spanish Super Cup in 2001, a European Super Cup in 2002, and an International Cup in 2002. During Vicente del Bosque's time as coach of Real Madrid, he directed 245 games and had 145 wins (54%), 58 draws (24%), and 55 losses (22%). In the 2004/2005 season, he was contracted by the Turkish team Besiktas, and in June 2007, he joined Cadiz FC's technical team under Arturo Baldasano, but left the position after just a few months. In 2008, he became manager of the Spanish national team, and led the team to their victory in the 2010 World Cup in South Africa, which was one of the criteria that secured his selection as a finalist for the World Coach of the Year in 2010.

As well as his outstanding achievements, both as player and coach, some of his personal characteristics influenced his work, and they have turned into key elements of his leadership style. Manager Ángel Martínez (2014) said the following about Vicente del Bosque:

> He is a leader who creates the space so people can express all their qualities and become the best versions of themselves. He knows how to generate trust, above all the team's trust in him, and never gets carried away by his ego. He has based his leadership, not on discipline but on strengths and team work. He has a special charisma that convinces the stars that they are going to shine in the team. Del Bosque doesn't convince people with screams or threats but by having a close relationship with them and presenting structured arguments. "Knowing how to listen is not a sign of weakness but a sign of strength", states the manager from Salamanca. His strongest argument is leading by example: he does not just talk about values but he is an example of them, and prioritizes surrounding himself with positive leaders (para. 1).

Del Bosque believes that leadership should be pleasant, cordial, and, above all, exciting; as no process of change or transformation is achieved without emotion. His philosophy as a manager highlights the principle that you cannot be a better leader than you already are as a person. Everyone

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points out that he is not only good-natured and a great listener, but he is also humble. Del Bosque is someone who thinks a master is an expert who always considers himself a beginner. He feels his profession to be a vocation, a mission that is educational in nature. His most difficult challenge is to educate in defeat and win people's trust to be able to contribute something positive to their lives.

He is not a man who enjoys the limelight, flattery, or conflict, but he knows how to impose his point of view when necessary and to be coherent and consistent. Maroto and Matallanas (2014) recall a time when Del Bosque was their coach at Real Madrid, and, several days before a crucial match with Atletico de Madrid in the Vicente Calderón Stadium (a game that would determine the Spanish Liga in 2003), Jorge Valdano, Del Bosque's boss, came to *Ciudad Deportiva* demanding that the coach isolate the team before the Atletico match, which was something that Del Bosque had never done in any of the games in Madrid, to give the players the chance to spend more time at home with their families. Del Bosque said to Valdano:

> I haven't done this all year and, if I do it now, in my opinion, we are going to send a message of doubt to our own players and a message of weakness to our rivals. I think that this could have the opposite effect to the one you are suggesting.

Nevertheless, the Argentine insisted and went to the dressing room to try to convince the players. He did not achieve what he hoped for.

Luca Caioli (2011) highlights Vicente del Bosque's modesty and simplicity: "*He was a man who did not like to just receive medals". In his book Vicente del Bosque: ¡Mil Gracias*! the author gathered 32 stories from sports personalities about the culture, society, and life of del Bosque. He affirms that the Spanish coach was transformed after the World Cup 2010 in South Africa into a model, into a mirror in which Spanish society felt reflected, hoping to see values they were missing:

> The Spanish coach is an example of values: of the values that society is in most need of today. Being a coach implies not only having sporting knowledge and knowing how to communicate it but also having excellent human training, fulfilling responsibilities and behaving responsibly, and, when possible, being an example for society. Winning is fundamental for a leader, but so is developing an educational role as sport is a perfect pedagogical tool. (Caioli, 2011).

A specific issue that should be considered when analyzing a coach's leadership skills is their relationship with players and management of their human talent. In this respect, Del Bosque's philosophy as a coach seems to be very clear: he is a leader who is capable of directing a group, he knows how to handle different abilities and talents, to hold them accountable, and also to create harmony as well as getting good results. For Del Bosque, the meaning of being a coach nowadays has changed; previously it meant ordering and enforcing, but today, above all, it requires the ability to convince, especially through training and knowledge. Previously, the coach appeared as if he knew everything because he was training alone, but now he is not working on his own anymore. He has a team that knows a lot about many different specialties. Today a coach cannot know everything, but

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he can surround himself with the best people and know how to effectively coordinate them. For the Spaniard, the ideal coach needs to be an example who, to be trustworthy, is completely moral, has an attitude of constant change, is in permanent training, does not succumb to easy success, knows how to observe, and to pay attention to the non-verbal language of his players.

A coach's two big decisions are to choose the correct sporting strategy and to establish a management style. There are many important factors to define the strategy. They need a game plan that depends on the players they have; a training method that is related to the players' profile and that is coherent with the strategy; to select players who form a stable team; to know how to build a team day after day, training session after training session, taking into consideration that a national team coach cannot have the experience with his team as a club coach does. They also need to rely on a technical team that freely expresses their opinions, as well as their disagreements, and feels part of the team.

In terms of management style, a changing room is a complex place of human relations. Del Bosque considers that human relationships are the key to success and that if these are successful then you are closer to achieving your objectives, which is evident in the long-term. One part of the difficulty of establishing good human relationships lies in the external influences on the teams and individuals, and, of course, in managing players who are not going to play: knowing how to keep their motivation, the performance, and the whole team as a unit. It should be recognized that, generally, it is usually easier to lead human groups in a national team than in a club; however, in both cases, there is a need for great humanity without losing sight of the players' backgrounds.

In terms of management style, there are several issues that a manager needs to handle: discipline, group cohesion, conflict resolution, communication style, delegating tasks, and, finally, achieving goals. In sports, just as in any other area of life, there is a need for discipline. Del Bosque's style is more permissive than authoritative. The Spanish coach recognizes this, yet affirms that he likes to lead by being very human but at the same time demanding. Although these styles can be very different, they need to be coherent in terms of being credible and making the players believe and follow the coach. Discipline is achieved with rules and respect, not with threats, making people do things, or having arguments.

There have been several articles in the press about Vicente del Bosque, and in an interview with *Executive Excellence*, he defined himself as a friendly leader (Gallardo, 2009). Moreover, Juan Carlos Cubeiro, who teaches leadership courses in the Spanish Football Federation, says the following about the coach:

> Unlike the [traditional] command and control leadership, Del Bosque has a serene and shared leadership style. He listens to everyone and knows what each player can contribute. (Fernández, 2010).

Francisco Mesonero, president of the Fundación Adecco and an expert in human resources, highlights that:

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> You could say that Del Bosque is the archetypical 21st century leader. He knows how to manage and create a human team with the values and attitude that today's society demands. He is not dominating with his decisions, but instead he convinces and provides security with his level-headedness. (Gómez, 2010).

He always maintained balance when facing diverse groups including the media.

2. Pep Guardiola[1] (Spain/Barcelona FC). Champions of the Clubs World Cup, Champions of the Spanish 'Liga', and Spanish Super Cup.

Josep Guardiola i Sala, known in the sports world as Pep Guardiola was born in Santpedor (Barcelona) on January 18, 1971. After a successful career both as a player and coaching FC Barcelona, he achieved the treble in his first season from the benches for the first team, and also won thirteen out of sixteen possible trophies.

Pep Guardiola, one of the most important players in the history of Barca, took over the first team on June 17, 2008 after a brilliant season with Barça Atlètic, which he managed to get promoted to the Second Division. On the day he won his first Joan Gamper Trophy he said:

> I can't promise trophies, but I can say that we will persist until the end and that you all will be proud of us.

And he was right. During his player career, Guardiola stood out for his class as a footballer, which was played almost entirely in FC Barcelona and later in Italy, Qatar, and Mexico. He played for Barca from when he started playing professionally in 1984 until he left for *Calcio* in 2001.

His achievements at FC Barcelona are acclaimed. In the 2008/09 season he won the treble: the Cup, the Liga, and the Champions; at the beginning of the 2009/10 season he won the Spanish Super Cup and the European Super Cup; in December 2009, for the first time in Barcelona's history, he won the Clubs World Cup. The magic of 2009 made it a historic year when Barcelona won six trophies: the Cup, Liga, Champions, Spanish Super Cup, European Super Cup, and the Clubs World Cup. The trophies just kept on coming, and then he won the Liga in 2009/10 as well as the Spanish Super Cup, the Liga, and the Champions in the following season.

In terms of personality, Pep Guardiola has a meticulous management style and looks after all the details. He prepares for matches with videos of the opposition and never looks beyond the following match. He is a brilliant motivator who brings out the best performance out of each man on his team. This philosophy allows him to achieve exceptional results. Xavier Hernández, known as Xavi and Guardiola's Team Captain, compares him to other managers:

[1] This data was taken from an article published by Barcelona FC on its official website. Accessed on June 15, 2011 from: http://www.fcbarcelona.es/club/historia/los-entrenadores

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> I have a lot of respect for Mourinho, but the ones who will go down in history will be either Guardiola, Sacchi, or Cruyff, maybe Fergurson. They have done something else; they have created a different game from what previously existed. And they have won. (Bruña, 2014, p. 157).

Xavi emphasizes that Pep thinks first before acting; he is a meticulous person, sometimes a storm of ideas when he dissects matches and the opponents to find the best way to attack them, to dominate them, and then to beat them.

Similarly, according to journalist Martí Perarnau, Guardiola is by definition a perfectionist who is always aiming for excellence. This is frequently manifested in his dissatisfaction with something about his team's game, even after a comfortable or convincing victory:

> We are not playing well, no, no, no, not at all. We work well, we get good results, and I am happy with the players, but we are not playing the way we need to play. I need all the players together and we need to improve. I need to have a better understanding of what this team needs in order to achieve its full potential. (Perarnau, 2014, p. 242).

As a reflection of his relationship with the players and his training style: Guardiola only understands one type of football: attacking, possession, and passing, which makes the opposing team run for the ball. He values his players' talent, but he makes sure that individual work and sacrifice contributes to the good of the team. He understands football as a team sport for which he is the one responsible for the results, and, therefore, he is the leader. Guardiola transmits a culture of excellence to his players that is accompanied by hard work, since they are not just going to win by playing brilliantly. His slogan is that you need to know how to shine and how to work hard. The important teams, the ones that go down in history and make a difference, are a group of artists who know how to sacrifice themselves for the good of the team.

According to Perarnau (2016), Guardiola is the best coach in the world because he has evolved eclectically and gave up the dogma of the Barca model. While adapting himself to the players, he gets the best out of them and manages to incorporate new tactical options into his team's games. Additionally, the author claims that there are four pillars of Guardiola's game: taking the initiative, having complementary players, combining in a synchronized way speed and slowing the game down, and engaging two powerful weapons: fixating players in an area and opening space.

> Pep thought that he would go through a process of mutual adaptation with the players but, in reality, it didn't work out exactly like that. This does not take place mutually and symmetrically for both parties; they are two different processes. One is adaptation and the other is learning. The coach adapts to the players and they learn a different way to organize their game. The conductor adapts to the instruments he is working with, but the musicians learn a different sheet music. (Perarnau, 2016, p. 103).

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Jorge Valdano, an ex-Argentinean player and Real Madrid coach who currently works as a sports analyst said the following about Guardiola's Barcelona:

> The extraordinary is the exception and never the rule. Analyzing what happened during Guardiola's time at Barcelona is like doing a thousand-piece puzzle or trying to understand a miracle. I have known prodigies such as Pelé's Brazil, Cruyff's Ajax, Sacchi's Milan, but I never thought it was possible to play so continuously with the efficiency and beauty of Barca during that time. (Valdano, 2016, p. 118).

According to the Argentinean expert, Guardiola is a very creative idealist who does not negotiate with his ideas and in Barca he demonstrated that he is a perverse innovator because, even when he was winning, he made some changes to seek excellence, without damaging the essence of the team. Valdano powerfully argues that Guardiola has made everyone change their viewpoint in terms of what football can and should be, and his sphere of influence even reached the Spanish national team during his most glorious period.

> If you want to look at the results, then add up the trophies. If you want to analyze the aesthetic, look at the worst game in his era (you will like it in comparison with so many bad games that we see every week). If you want to see it from a social identification viewpoint, I think that there is no Barcelona fan who doesn't feel proud of the world recognition that was achieved. (Valdano, 2016, p. 119).

In *Pep Guardiola. Another Way of Winning* (2012), the author, journalist Guillem Balagué, quotes the Argentinean Javier Mascherano:

> Never in my career have I seen a dressing room full of footballers who follow a coach with so much faith. Pep has the gift of leadership.

The Catalan journalist states in his research that part of Pep's magic lies in a very seductive mixture: on one side, his fragility, including physical fragility; and on the other side the strength of his leadership and of his own personality, which are two contradictory facets that can also be seen in his teams.

> Guardiola earned his authority, not only with his team and the results achieved, but also through his attitude in the good and the bad, with his achievements, and also with the errors that he himself confessed. The cynics said that his composure and exemplary behavior were just a front. (Balagué, 2016, p. 297).

These were Guardiola's words about Jose Mourinho when he signed for Real Madrid in the 2010-2011 season:

> Mourinho will make me a better coach. It is important that he works in Spain because he is one of the best coaches in the world. He will make us all better. (Balague, 2010, p. 307).

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Another expert consulted, Miguel Ángel Violan, states that Guardiola is a charismatic, attractive, magnetic, and transformative leader.

> He is someone who can change the attitudes of those he is in charge of and get the best out of them. Let's put it this way: he is a positive person. He learns the lesson of whatever circumstances he finds himself in and this makes him stronger and more mature. (Violan, 2010, p. 73).

In terms of Guardiola's most important leadership characteristics, he points out the capacity to mentally prepare his people and be believable, which also means having influence and clarity of ideas as well as the capacity to get people to follow him on the route he has mapped out.

> Guardiola has turned footballers into disciples, followers of the truth. He is –if I can use the word– an evangelizer. He has sent a message, and his message has had an impact. (Violan, 2010, p. 74).

Some members of the press said that, at the beginning of the 2010 season, many people expressed their doubts about Pep Guardiola's chance of success due to his lack of experience and not-very-autocratic leadership style. However, his efficiency in achieving results changed people's opinions (Cruz, 2009). According to the same sources, the keys to his success were his major involvement and demanding a lot from his players; his positive leadership and communication style; common objectives and sensitivity to individual differences; and his coherence throughout the season. Similarly, an academic study signaled that Pep is obsessed with his work, improving, and managing product quality as he is looking for a good game that gives results. He is client focused (he has said "we play for the people" on more than one occasion) and knows how to manage effectiveness aimed at getting results, the ambition of achievement, and the desire to succeed (Gómez, 2010). Guardiola rarely gives press interviews.

3. José Mourinho (Portugal/FC Internazionale Milano and Real Madrid FC). Champions of the Italian League, champions of the Italy Cup and Champions League.

José Mourinho was born in Portugal on January 26, 1963 in Setúbal (Portugal). According to experts, he is one of the best coaches of all time. His father is Félix Mourinho, an ex-footballer and coach. His mother, María Julia, worked as a school teacher. José first appeared in the media in the 1990s when he was Sir. Bobby Robson's assistant in Sporting Lisbon and in FC Porto. He continued to work with Robson when he transferred to FC Barcelona in 1996; however, some questioned his role in the Catalan team. Journalists thought he was just a simultaneous interpreter as he spoke English, Italian, French, Spanish, and Portuguese fluently.

In 2000 he terminated his contract with Barcelona during Louis van Gaal's time to coach Benfica from Lisboa, replacing Jupp Heynckes. However, the team changed its coaching team half way through the season and they decided to terminate Mourinho's contract after just nine games. One year later, he was leading Uniao de Leiria, and he took the team to the fifth position in the

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general classification. With this team, Mourinho ended his apprenticeship; he was now ready to be on the front pages of the sports papers.

In 2002 he was signed by FC Porto, which is one of the big three clubs in the Portuguese premier league. Ever since he took over the club, Mourinho was acknowledged for his success and his self-confidence when talking to the media. Under his leadership, the Portuguese club won three titles in the 2002/2003 season: the League, the Cup and the UEFA Cup. In the following season, he won the Portuguese league and the Champions League, which got them into the 2004 Intercontinental Cup, which they won in penalties against the unexpected Once Caldas from Colombia.

The next challenge was when he signed with Chelsea FC. When Mourinho arrived in London, he told the media that he thought he was special when being asked about the reasons for his success:

> even more special than any of my predecessors who had led the team.

Since then, he has been known as '*The Special One*'. Mourinho then went to Inter Milan and secured his position as one of the best coaches on the planet; the Italian team achieved surprising results: they were twice champions of the Serie A and won one Champions League. "God must think that I am an amazing guy. He wouldn't have given me so much otherwise", stated the Portuguese coach during an interview with the Spanish press when he had just stared with Real Madrid at the beginning of 2010.

Authenticity is an essential part of Mourinho's character. He is not a hypocrite: he says what he thinks and does what he wants:

> I win a match and I celebrate with my players the way I want to. I win another and if I am not interested in celebrating, I leave. Sometimes I win and I forget to say goodbye to the opposing coach because I just want to be with my players. Sometimes I am angry because I am angry, sometimes I am angry because I want to appear angry (Vasco, 2012, p. 25).

He is a conflictive leader who is either loved or hated. Those who love him say that, as well as being an excellent trainer, he is a friend and safe place for his players (Diego Milito). He has a great deal of self-confidence:

> Of course I am able to win the Champions with Madrid. I would like to be the first to win the European League "Grand Slam". "In 2010, on a scale of 1 to 10, I give myself an 11.

His critics agree that he is an authoritarian leader and extremely unjust. In Real Madrid, Mourinho got into a fight with Mesut Ozil and Casillas who did not hesitate to criticize him and question his professionalism and devotion on the training ground. Mourinho is a coach who demands a lot of commitment and sacrifice from his players and does not tolerate anything different from what he asks. Hence, he can give the impression of being totally intolerant and, on occasions, a

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sort of dictator, because he has the tendency to severely reprimand and criticize when things do not go the way he wants.

Guillem Balagué (2012), a journalist for *Sky Spots*, says that when he was manager in FC Barcelona, the Dutchman Louis van Gaal remembered Mourinho in the following way:

> He was young and arrogant and didn't have too much respect for authority, but I liked that about him. He was not submissive; he used to contradict me when he thought I wasn't right. I came to the conclusion that I was interested in his opinion and ended up listening more to him than I did to the rest of the coaching team (Balague, 2012, p. 301).

When he was coaching Inter Milan, he eliminated Barcelona in the Champions (3-1 in Milan and 1-0 in Barcelona). He stated:

> It is always hard to lose, especially for those who are not used to losing. We are chasing a dream, Barcelona is not. They are obsessed with something called Santiago Bernabéu (Balaqué, 2012, p. 304).

Balagué says that just before signing as coach of Real Madrid, Mourinho knew that Barcelona had to be knocked off their pedestal. To achieve this, he had to use all the weapons in his arsenal of words, gestures, accusations, and insinuations:

> We are used to seeing Barcelona players falling down. (Balague, 2012, p. 305).

If Pep Guardiola's biggest virtue is caution, Mourinho's is pure excess, even when speaking about the future:

> I am going to win the League here and then in two-year's-time in a different country… and when I am fifty, I'll win the World Cup with Portugal.

Mourinho stands out for clearly knowing what he wants, but for not being too affected if his plans don't work out. The day that he lost 5-0 to Guardiola's Barcelona as Real Madrid's coach, he said:

> I can easily accept this result. It is not a humiliation, just my biggest defeat.

Eleonora Giovio, author of "*El Efecto Mourinho: Tierra Quemada*,"[2] confirms his obsession, almost to the point of illness, with winning. Arrigo Sacchi, the Italian ex-manager and an authority in the world of football writes the following in his book "*José Mourinho. El entrenador alienígena*":[3]

[2] Book available in Spanish.

[3] Book available in Spanish.

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> José Mourinho: veni, vidi, vici. He arrived in Italy, won, and then left. We will miss him. Mourinho is a one-off. He is an intelligent and cultured man who is driven by a strong ego and by a huge passion for football. He has managed his teams masterfully, both tactically and psychologically. He is a leader capable of bringing the most hidden human resources to light and giving everyone security and conviction. He is a skillful and imaginative strategist who has great energy and an unequalled ability to win. His way of doing things has revolutionized the old Italian world of football. Maybe he has sometimes exaggerated when getting into embittered controversies with colleagues and journalists. No one is perfect! But he has an amazing CV" (Modeo, 2010, p. 13).

Sacchi believes that Mourinho's most prominent virtues are: being meticulous, as he leaves nothing to chance. Having conviction, which makes his players admire him. Being sure of himself, which means that he is a reliable guide. Having a strong and determined character, which means he is respected -if not feared-. Being professional and having a culture of working hard as he has a passion for and dedication to football. Being an original thinker. Having the ability to be didactic and communicative, he is never banal and is always well informed. Moreover, having the ability to be both the lightning conductor and the driving force. All of these make Mourinho a great manager and undisputed leader: he is unique; there are no clones (Modeo, 2010, p. 14).

According to the expert Sandro Modeo, Mourinho has certain characteristics: hubris ("I think I'm a special one", "I am not the best in the world, but I don't think there is anyone better than me"). His appearance is affected by the team's performance; for example, his tie is open and loose when the match finishes, which shows he is just one of the players. He has an ability to create publicity for himself and to turn himself into a brand to sell dreams and be a master in the art of persuasion. In addition, he uses mobility as success, and his the desire to escape is a sign of affinity and freedom (Modeo, 2010, pp. 27-29).

The relationship he establishes with his players has a narrative and is highly emotional, and he uses a method that could be summarized in the following way:

> Just like his whole way of behaving, it is a complicated overlapping of elements, of illustrated pedagogy and subtle tricks, of ethical sensibility and strategic cynicism, and of deep loyalty and demonic cunning. All of this, it must be said, can be understood to be at the service of the categorical and, by definition amoral, imperative: Victory (Modeo, 2010, p. 74).

In order to achieve this, he uses various mechanisms in his human and group relationships throughout which he establishes himself as a leader: reciprocity, which is sealed in an explicit and fundamental agreement with the team: "follow me in everything and I will make you win everything". He has a mix of commitment and coherence: he is always responsible for the results. He uses social acceptance, which is substantiated in the most influential elements of the group. He also used understanding, which is formed with his master use of flattery: he has the ability to be able to get into the mind of his listener and change his communication depending on who he is speaking to. He also has authority, and uses subliminal symbols that create intense and extreme feelings in order to make everyone love and respect his authority and for nobody to question it (Modeo, 2010, pp. 74-82).

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Pedro Vasco upholds his claim that Mourinho is the best coach in the world:

> Am I exaggerating? We will see. In a career spanning less than twelve years, which began in September 2000, José Mourinho has won 19 trophies. Seven championships in four different countries. He won at FC Porto with low-cost players against low level clubs; he won at Chelsea with footballers who hadn't won anything (except a lot of money); he won at Inter with immense veteran athletes; and he won at Real Madrid with great players whose average age was less than 25. He won in Portugal, England, Italy, and Spain; he won with a little and a lot of money; he won with veteran and young players (Vasco, 2012, p. 8).

This is something that cannot be said about the other coaches in the shortlist. Teams are reborn from the ashes with Mourinho: they change direction and rhythm, they transcend their defects, they transmute. Mourinho does not just restrict himself to inheriting what he has and changing as little as possible; whatever he achieves has his unique stamp, concludes Vasco.

The Colombian journalist Lizeth Torres claims that Mourinho is a leader and visionary who has a lot of charisma and manages to get the players to believe in him as well as in his objective. Curiously, however, his ability to influence declines as rapidly as it grows.

> He is a born winner who is always focused on winning and does not accept defeat as he does not accept the role of loser. Guardiola is a great manager, but he won the Champions League embarrassingly because of the scandal at Stamford Bridge. And if they win this year, it will be because of the scandal at Bernabéu.

He has been fined on several occasions for accusations against referees. To summarize, from a media point of view, José Mourinho is perhaps the most controversial of the three coaches because of his strong, cutting, and decisive character. Michael Robinson, ex-footballer and panelist on Canal+ says the following:

> He puts on a show for the media, but he is a great communicator and generous with footballers. He lets them know that they are the ones who win and he is the one who loses, and for this reason, they love him. He gives them love and respect, he is more soft than hard. His dialectical battles are monumental. There are small moments in a life that inspire a special type of affection (Cruz, 2010, para. 8).

In an interview with the Spanish newspaper *El País*, Mourinho highlights that his thinking is the result of a union between two areas that some believe to be incompatible: the universality and football. His philosophy is about working properly and strongly.

> Many work strongly but not well, and many work well but not strongly. [It is necessary] to create strong leadership for the players that [is] properly accepted, not just because it is a leadership due to power or status.

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CHARACTERISTICS OF THE FOOTBALL PLAYERS

Annex 1 includes the complete teams who played under Del Bosque, Guardiola, and Mourinho from November 2009 to November 2010. The table includes each player's position and their age. All teams were renowned for their great physical fitness and footballing talent, so we can conclude that each of the three coaches had at their hands privileged human resources.

Experts' comments about the teams indicate that, for the Spanish national team, Del Bosque inherited the best team of players in history who were at their best moment in football. Guardiola's Barcelona stands out because of Messi, the best footballer in the world, who was accompanied by other excellent footballers that were also trained in the club's lower levels. The team had a well-integrated game and defined style. Finally, Mourinho's Inter stands out for his ability to "motivate", "recover", and then win with players who had been cast aside by other clubs because of their age or due to their conflictive nature.

XABI ALONSO: AN EXPERT WITNESS

Few players can say that they were managed by Vicente del Bosque, Pep Guardiola, and José Mourinho. One of them is Xabier Alonso Olano, known as Xabi Alonso, who was born in Tolosa in the Spanish province of Guipúzcoa, in 1981. He played for Real Madrid, the Spanish national team, and Bayern Munich, and stands out for being one of the most cosmopolitan and chameleonic European players with a recognized ability to adapt.

Enrique Marín in his book, "*Xabi Alonso, un modelo de futbolista*,"[4] highlights the Spanish player's professionalism, education, elegance, character, discretion, and composure. He has a CV that is full of success on both Clubs and at the National Teams and always plays an important role in said teams. Vicente del Bosque has, on many occasions, defended they key role Xabi Alonso has played in the national team's success and his good example both on and off the pitch. When Xabi Alonso announced his retirement, the manager claimed it was difficult to improve what he had done:

> He has left a brilliant legacy. He has been a great professional.

When he was a Bayern Munich player, Xabi Alonso gave a long interview to Jorge Valdano for the channel beIN SPORTS (Maestro, 2016), in which he talked about the three coaches who were the finalists of the "FIFA World Coach of the Year" award. About Vicente del Bosque, he said:

> He gave us a lot of freedom as he knew we were responsible players with a shared direction who always thought about the best for the team and that we had the necessary idea for strategy. He is a football man; he loves football, playing piggy-in-the-middle, an inside pass, when the ball sounds good. He trusted us a lot. He knew how to tell which

[4] Book available in Spanish.

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> players could get on well together. He had the intelligence to work on what had already been achieved by Luis Aragonés (the former Spain coach). He was similar to Ancelotti: they both know how to win over the dressing room, how to get on with people, and then they were intelligent enough to make decisions about football, training, games, tactics, based on managing the dressing room and the team.

About Guardiola, he stated:

> Pep Guardiola looks for perfection in football; he creates a way of playing that has a great impact, not just because the players are good but because both him and his team work really well: they are meticulous, perfectionists, hard-workers and know where they want to get to. He works on ideas not just once but until he has created automatisms. He repeats what has been done and then you are taught again how to do it better or what you have to improve. He is very pragmatic: he knows what he wants, and if he has to follow a certain route, he does. He is very flexible when making decisions, proposals, or changing the system in search of what he wants. He is very creative when looking for alternatives and also when anticipating decisions.

Finally, when speaking about José Mourinho, he said:

> He is 100% competitive and all he wants to do is win. He incites the players, the club, and the fans, and I think that he changed things. He made us compete against Pep's great Barca, and he knew how to get the best out of many of us. He made us play at an excellent level, and we won a great League, but three times we lost the Champions League final…it was a really positive phase for the club. He was controversial because of his personality and his temper. He demands a lot from himself as well as 100% from the players. If he doesn't like someone, he changes them into what he wants, and sometimes this change can be managed in a way that can be understood and sometimes it can create tension that can't be resolved. But that's his personality; he is euphoric and very passionate, both in victory and defeat. It meant a lot to the team to see the charisma and aura that he had. He transmitted it. Pep is like this as well. Pep also feels a lot: when things don't go the right way, he feels it. He assumes his position as a leader very well.

In an interview for Libero, the writer Javier Aznar said that Xabi Alonso told him that Guardiola and Mourinho share common traits: they are hard workers, perfectionists, and have a code:

> They are the best managers that I have had. What impacted me most about Mourinho was his talks in seemingly unimportant matches. Let's say we were easily beating a middle-bottom table team; he would come into the dressing room and give us an incredible scolding. It was like something out of a movie. And then he was calmer in important matches in the Champions or against Barca because you really have to concentrate in these games, but in the others you don't. One of the things Mourinho only said once, but that I really liked was: "I don't make the team, you do. (para. 24).

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Xabi Alonso emphasized the following about Guardiola:

> He is very meticulous and a hard worker. It has to be like that; there is no other way. Guardiola has won everything he has because of his undeniable work ethics and not just because of a pre-determined style of play. He is obsessed with football. He is always on top of things. What I value the most about him is his ability to convince the players and that you truly feel what he, as a manager, wants and believes. I also like his clear vision of what he has and wants from his team and how he works hard to speak to the players in the best way (Aznar, 2017, para. 21.).

It seems that Xabi Alonso does not have such a high opinion of Vicente del Bosque although he does emphasize his ability to integrate and coordinate players who have a lot of experience with much younger ones: "*The coach is very dynamic and flexible*" (Aznar, 2017, para, 5). Perhaps Xabi Alonso's discretion explains why he has not lavished praise on Del Bosque as the player´s career in the Spanish National team did not end well. He quit the team when they were eliminated from the World Cup in Brazil, where Spain performed poorly. The player ended up arguing with most of the squad because of his controversial statements; he said that Spain's poor performance against Brazil was because the team was just not 'hungry' enough. However, on several occasions he has shown gratitude to Del Bosque for having initiated him in the Spanish team, and, therefore, making him a star of true sporting achievements.

ONLY A FEW DAYS LEFT BEFORE THE VOTE

The "World Coach of the Year" was to be chosen on January 10, 2011. Each one of the finalists was unique and different from each other, and they had sufficiently important achievements to deserve the Award. Vicente del Bosque took over the Spanish National Team with the best football team in the world that played such high-quality football that it could, historically, only be compared to Brazil. Mourinho, had inherited an Italian team with which no one had been able to do what he did: turn Inter Milan into the best club in Italy and Europe with players who, in the opinion of sports journalists, were in decline or close to retirement. These two might well have been the bookmakers' favorites, but Guardiola could not be discounted. He had the accolade of having turned his FC Barcelona into the "best team in history": on December 19, 2009, after beating *Estudiantes de la Plata* in an epic match, Guardiola's Barcelona made history as the only team in the world that was capable of winning the six competitions they had entered.

The FIFA judges only had a few weeks to decide on their final vote and chose the first winner of this important award. They needed to consider the following criteria: the difficulty of the games played and quality of the coaches' results in the previous season, the personality traits of each coach, their characteristics as leaders, their relationships with their teams, and the features of the players that would have influenced the results. If you had been a judge, who would you have voted for as the 'World Coach of the Year'?

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Exhibit 1. *List of players under each one of the coaches*

	Inter Mourinho	Barcelona Guardiola	Spanish national team Del Bosque
	Julio César (goalkeeper, Age: 31)	Víctor Valdés (goalkeeper, Age: 28)	Iker Casillas (goalkeeper, Age: 29)
	Lucio (defense, Age: 32)	Gerard Piqué (defense, Age: 23)	Sergio Ramos (defense, Age: 27)
	Maicon Sesinando (defense, Age: 29)	Carles Puyol (defense, Age: 32)	Gerard Piqué (defense, Age: 23)
	Walter Samuel (defense, Age: 32)	Maxwell Andrade (defense, Age: 29)	Carlos Marchena (defense - midfield, Age: 31)
	Thiago Motta (defense, Age: 28)	Sergio Busquets (defense- midfield, Age: 22)	Carles Puyol (defense, Age: 32)
	Cristian Chivu (defense, Age: 30)	Xavi Hernández (midfield, Age: 30)	Sergio Busquets (defense - midfield, Age: 22)
	Javier Zanetti (defense, Age: 37)	Andrés Iniesta (midfield, Age: 26) (An injury that lasted a long time prevented him from playing in many key games).	Xabi Alonso (midfield, Age: 29)
	Esteban Cambiasso (midfield, Age: 30)	Seydou Keita (midfield, Age: 30)	Xavi Hernández (midfield, Age: 30)
	Wesley Sneijder (midfield, Age: 26)	Pedro Rodríguez (forward-wing, Age: 23)	Andrés Iniesta (midfield, Age: 26)
	Samuel Eto´o (forward, Age: 29)	Ibrahimovic (forward, Age: 29)	Pedro Rodríguez (forward - wing, Age: 23)
	Diego Milito (forward, Age: 31)	Lionel Messi (forward, Age: 23)	David Villa (forward, Age: 29)
	Goran Pandev (forward, Age: 27)	Eric Abidal (defense, Age: 31)	Jesús Navas (forward -wing, Age: 25)
	Dejan Stankovic (midfield, Age: 32)	Yaya Touré (midfield, Age: 27)	Cesc Fábregas (midfield, Age: 23)
	Sulley Muntari (midfield, Age: 26)	Bojan Krkic (forward, Age: 20)	Fernando Torres (forward, Age: 26)
	Marco Materazzi (defense, Age: 37)	Jeffren Suárez (midfield, Age: 22)	Joan Capdevila (defense, Age: 32)
	Iván Córdoba (defense, Age: 34)	Thierry Henry (forward, Age: 33)	Juan Mata (midfield, Age: 22)
	Philippe Coutinho (midfield, Age: 18)	Rafael Márquez (defense- midfield, Age: 31)	David Silva (midfield -forward, Age: 24)
	David Suazo (forward, Age: 31)	Gabriel Milito (defense, Age: 30)	Javi Martínez (defense - midfield, Age: 22)
	Andrea Ranoccnia (defense, Age: 22)	Gudjhonsen (forward, Age: 32)	Álvaro Arbeloa (defense, Age: 27)
	Giampaolo Pazzini (forward, Age: 26)	José Manuel Pinto (goalkeeper, Age: 35)	Pepe Reina (goalkeeper, Age: 28)
	Houssine Kharja (midfield, Age: 28)	Javier Mascherano (defense-midfield, Age: 26)	David de Gea (goalkeeper, Age: 20)
	Jonathan Biabiany (forward, Age: 22)	Adriano Correia (defense, Age: 26)	César Azpilicueta (defense, Age: 21)
	Yūto Nagatomo (defense, Age: 27)	Ibrahim Afellay (forward, Age: 24)	Juanfran (defense, Age: 25)
	Davide Santon (defense, Age: 19)	Thiago Alcántara (midfield, Age: 19)	Koke Resurrección (midfield, Age: 28)
	McDonald M. Wanyama (midfield, Age: 23)	Andreu Fontás (defense, Age: 21)	Raúl Albiol (defense, Age: 25)
	Joel Chukwuma Obi (midfield, Age: 19)	Marc Bartra (defense, Age: 19)	
Team (number of starting and reserve players who played more than 10 matches a year)	26	26	25
Average age (total)	27.9	26.5	24.96
Average age (starting team)	30.3	26.4	27.4

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